

Psalms 38

Under Heavy Chastening

Thine arrows stick fast in me
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 O LORD, rebuke me not in thy wrath: neither chasten me in thy hot displeasure.
- 2 For thine arrows stick fast in me, and thy hand presseth me sore.
- 3 There is no soundness in my flesh because of thine anger; neither is there any rest in my bones because of my sin.
- 4 For mine iniquities are gone over mine head: as an heavy burden they are too heavy for me.
- 5 My wounds stink and are corrupt because of my foolishness.
- 6 I am troubled; I am bowed down greatly; I go mourning all the day long.
- 7 For my loins are filled with a loathsome disease: and there is no soundness in my flesh.
- 8 I am feeble and sore broken: I have roared by reason of the disquietness of my heart.
- 9 Lord, all my desire is before thee; and my groaning is not hid from thee.
- 10 My heart panteth, my strength faileth me: as for the light of mine eyes, it also is gone from me.
- 11 My lovers and my friends stand aloof from my sore; and my kinsmen stand afar off.
- 12 They also that seek after my life lay snares for me: and they that seek my hurt speak mischievous things, and imagine deceits all the day long.
- 13 But I, as a deaf man, heard not; and I was as a dumb man that openeth not his mouth.
- 14 Thus I was as a man that heareth not, and in whose mouth are no reproofs.
- 15 For in thee, O LORD, do I hope: thou wilt hear, O Lord my God.
- 16 For I said, Hear me, lest otherwise they should rejoice over me: when my foot slippeth, they magnify themselves against me.
- 17 For I am ready to halt, and my sorrow is continually before me.
- 18 For I will declare mine iniquity; I will be sorry for my sin.
- 19 But mine enemies are lively, and they are strong: and they that hate me wrongfully are multiplied.
- 20 They also that render evil for good are mine adversaries; because I follow the thing that good is.
- 21 Forsake me not, O LORD: O my God, be not far from me.
- 22 Make haste to help me, O Lord my salvation.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 38 is the third traditional penitential psalm, written by David “to bring to remembrance” a season under God’s disciplining hand combined with sickness, abandoned friendships, and enemies actively plotting his harm. Its physical imagery is unusually raw—wounds that stink and are corrupt, loins filled with pain, a heart that roars for disquietness—paired with a striking silence before mockers and a final short, urgent plea. Henry treats it as a model for bringing both real guilt and real suffering honestly to God, without excusing the sin yet without giving up on mercy.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

A plea not to be rebuked in anger; God’s arrows stick fast and His hand presses heavily. There is no soundness in his flesh because of God’s anger, no rest in his bones because of his sin, for his iniquities have gone over his head like a heavy burden too heavy to bear.

Verse 5-8

His wounds stink and are corrupt through his own foolishness; he is troubled and bowed down greatly, mourning all the day. His loins are filled with pain, there is no soundness in his flesh; he is feeble and sore broken, roaring for the disquietness of his heart.

Verse 9-12

Every desire is known before the Lord, his groaning not hidden. His heart pants, his strength fails, and even the light of his eyes is gone. His lovers and friends stand aloof because of his affliction, while those seeking his life lay snares, speak mischief, and imagine deceit all day long.

Verse 13-16

Like a deaf man he does not hear, like a dumb man he does not open his mouth to answer—he chooses not to defend himself. Instead he hopes in the Lord to answer for him, asking only that his enemies not rejoice over him when his foot slips.

Verse 17-20

He is ready to halt, and his sorrow is continually before him; he confesses his iniquity and is anxious over his sin. Meanwhile his enemies are lively and strong, and many hate him wrongfully, rendering evil for good because he follows what is good.

Verse 21-22

The psalm ends with two short, urgent cries: “Forsake me not, O Lord: O my God, be not far from me. Make haste to help me, O Lord my salvation.”

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

It is possible to be genuinely guilty and genuinely suffering at the same time, and to bring both realities—confessed sin and undeserved hostility—into the same prayer without resolving which one is “worse.” Silence before mockers is not weakness when it is paired with active hope placed in God to answer on one’s behalf.

Application for life today.

If you are carrying both guilt and unfair opposition at once, let this psalm give you permission to name both rather than picking one to focus on. Practice verses 13–15’s restraint: choose not to answer every provocation, and instead pray for God to be your answer. Use the short, direct prayers of verses 21–22 as your own—“forsake me not… make haste to help me”—when you have no more words.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where are you currently carrying both real guilt and real unfair treatment, and how might naming both to God (rather than just one) help?

2. What would it look like to stay “deaf” and “dumb” (v. 13) toward a provocation this week, trusting God to answer for you instead?

3. Which of the two closing prayers—“forsake me not” or “make haste to help me”—do you need to pray right now, and about what?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).